

Emergency Escape Openings and Window Wells

Every bedroom needs a hole big enough to climb out of. Five numbers define it, and the exam loves a window that fails on arithmetic.

An emergency escape and rescue opening has to be large enough for an adult in gear to get in as well as for an occupant to get out. That is why there is a minimum area as well as minimum dimensions — you can satisfy both the height and the width and still fail the area.

The numbers here

Minimum net clear opening area	5.7 sq ft
Minimum net clear opening height	24 in
Minimum net clear opening width	20 in
Maximum height from the floor to the bottom of the clear opening	44 in
Grade-floor opening — the one exception to the area	5.0 sq ft
Egress door — minimum clear opening	32 in wide x 78 in high
Egress door — width	36 in

The arithmetic trap, asked directly

A bedroom window measures exactly 24 inches high by 20 inches wide. It meets both minimum dimensions — and it fails, because it provides only 3.3 square feet against the 5.7 required. Minimum height and minimum width together do not produce the minimum area. One of them has to be larger than its minimum.

Where they are required	Every sleeping room, and every basement — including a habitable attic.
Operability	Must be operable from inside without keys, tools or special knowledge. A window painted shut, or one needing a key, fails however big it is. Bars and screens are allowed only if they release the same way.
The exempt basement	One without habitable space and without any storage or utility area needs no escape opening.

Window wells

The numbers here

Window well — minimum net clear area	9 sq ft
Window well — minimum horizontal projection and width	36 in
Window well — permanent ladder or steps required when deeper than	44 in

Forty-four inches appears twice and means two different things: the maximum sill height inside the room, and the well depth at which a ladder becomes required outside it. Both are about the same body climbing the same distance.

Say it back

Cover the page. Answer each one out loud.

1. Give the five escape opening numbers.
2. A window is exactly 24 by 20. Does it comply? Show the arithmetic.
3. Which rooms require an escape opening, and which basement is exempt?
4. State the operability rule.
5. Window well area, projection, and the depth needing a ladder?
6. Egress door width, and its minimum clear opening?
7. Where does 44 inches appear twice, and what does it mean each time?